

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X

7-0 (A)

Species: White-eyed Vireo (*Vireo griseus*)

Red 9/2/00 upl

Date: 12 June 2000**Number seen:** one**Sex:** male**Plumage:** Alternate?**Locality:** along Purgatoire River, just east of Lorencito, south of the RR tracks on the south side of Hwy 12, and about 0.5 mi. west of 41.7 Rd., west of Trinidad Lake (DeLorme pg 93 C.5, 4.25)**Elevation:** about 6600'**Nearest town:** Lorencito**County:** Las Animas**Time observed:** about 9:20 - 9:45 MDT**Duration of observation:** total of about 10 minutes in that time

Description: While exploring Las Animas Co. for various bird species for CBO's Monitoring Colorado's Birds program, I was driving west on Hwy 12 approaching the tiny "town" of Lorencito. As I was going around a bend, the Purgatoire River approached the road quite closely and the riparian vegetation looked interesting, so I stopped to see what I could find (being particularly interested in padding my Las Animas Co. list). Less than 10 seconds after getting out of the car and crossing to the river side of the road, I heard a song that I thought was that of a White-eyed Vireo. I was a bit incredulous, but the species has a very distinctive song with which I was very familiar from many years living in the east where it is quite a common species. I waited with bated breath for it to sing again. Fortunately, about 20 seconds later, it did. I worked my way down onto the RR tracks and then east toward the bird and finally slapped bins on it. It was in a thick, shrubby willow and would occasionally stop foraging and belt out its song. I could not find it when I tried to photograph it 30 minutes later or the next day when I stopped again.

The bird was a small vireo, about the size of a Yellow Warbler, but chunkier. Its head was mostly gray with a white chin and throat, yellow spectacles, and whitish eyes (the color was difficult to discern except at close range). The back was greeny and the tail and wings were dark, the latter with two obvious, white wingbars. The sides and flanks were extensively yellow and there was white down the center of the underparts. I did not see (or note) the color of the vent area. The legs were dark, as was the bill (which was thick and hooked).

Similar species eliminated by description: No other North American bird has a song that can be readily confused with that of White-eyed Vireo. In addition, the combination of plumage characters is not matched by other North American species. These features and the pale irides rule out Bell's and Yellow-throated vireos, probably the two most similar species.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): The song was a jumble of musical notes with harsh, low-pitched beginning and ending notes that I transliterated as "chuck" - "chuck chaweeah-weeah chuck"

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen and heard many 100s of White-eyed Vireos, particularly while at Cape May where the species is incredibly numerous. I have also seen 100s of Yellow-throated Vireos and a small handful of eastern-race Bell's.

Light conditions: sun to my left

Optical equipment used: Zeiss 7x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at about 11 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: none

Other observers who saw the bird independently: none

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:



Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: This report was written on 29 August 2000 from notes written at the time of the sighting.